inter-state water disputes and language politics, Annamalai says he does not know Hindi, opposes its imposition on Tamils and calls himself a pure Dravidian. He also quotes extensively from Tamil literature in his tweets to emphasise that the BJP isn't opposed to Tamil. He's also adept at oppositional politics, travelling extensively to mobilise the cadre and keeping an eagle eye on perceived lapses in governance so as to skewer the ruling DMK. And the BJP chief, an engineer and IIM Lucknow graduate, also does not wish to take the bait offered by angry AIADMK leaders and jeopardise the alliance. "We are controlling 'narrative politics', and this has bettered our position in the minds of Tamils. We are calling out DMK's falling governance standards, levelling corruption charges with evidence, and anti-incumbency against the ruling government seems to have arrived early," says an upbeat Annamalai.

"He is seen everywhere, heard every day, but is overdoing it and doing it too early. Voters may tire of him before the Lok Sabha polls arrive," muses political commentator N. Sathiya Moorthy. "He began well, but in his zeal, he may imperil both the party and himself." His aggressive expansionism may trigger anxiety in AIADMK ranks, but many feel just that is not enough. "We are focused on strengthening our grassroots; balancing the energy of the youth and the insight of veterans is letting us explore new territories," says Annamalai. " We are meeting people across districts, and after seeing the reception that we receive, Tamil Nadu BJP is confident of winning over the hearts and minds of the people by 2026." Annamalai's agenda is easier declared than done. ■



PTI

BAD WEATHER
Will Akhilesh retain his momentum?

UTTAR PRADESH

AZAM, AZAMGARH... THE A-Z OF TROUBLES

By Prashant Srivastava

Just months after mounting a challenge to Yogi Adityanath in the Uttar Pradesh election, Samajwadi Party chief Akhilesh Yadav is himself beset by a twin challenge. One is external: he has to save the party's bastions Azamgarh and Rampur in Lok Sabha bypolls due on June 23. Both are prestige seats, having been vacated by Akhilesh himself and party stalwart Azam Khan, respectively, when they moved to the assembly in March. The other is internal: quelling dissension from uncle Shivpal Yadav and Azam Khan. The first has a strong internal component too, mapped by the drama that preceded candidate selection—the party managed to finalise names just hours before the nomination wound up.

After a spell of confusion, the party went with conservative choices, yet not entirely untouched by controversy. From Azamgarh, it has fielded Dharmendra Yadav, former MP from Badaun and a member of Yadav family; in Rampur, Azam Khan aide Asim Raza will do the honours. Says an SP functionary: "A part of the Azamgarh unit wanted Dimple Yadav to contest. And in Rampur, they initially wished to reserve the ticket for Azam's own family. Neither has happened. The bypolls are not going to be easy."

The BJP is not the only source of tension. Even the BSP seems to have joined hands with it to make the SP bite the dust. Azamgarh has a sizeable Muslim and Yadav population, traditionally the core of the SP's support base. This time, the BSP has fielded local leader Shah Alam a.k.a. Guddu Jamali, whose connect with the Muslim community may chip away at that core. In Rampur, the

CHALLENGES FOR AKHILESH

- To save bastions Azamgarh and Rampur in the Lok Sabha bypolls due on June 23
- To retain the momentum he built before the assembly polls; to tend to the cracks visible during candidate selection
- To manage uncle Shivpal Yadav and Azam Khan
- To keep all other alliance partners–SBSP, Apna Dal (K), RLD et al–with SP